

The Finished Web

Eight Tellings

A stylized, handwritten-style signature or logo, possibly reading 'GPA'.A handwritten signature, likely 'H. H. H. H.', written in a cursive style.

There is another book, which says that the web of time is still being spun: that the past is fixed, the future is empty air, and the living stand at the edge of it all, making tomorrow one thread at a time. It is true. It is the web as the living feel it, from inside. These are the tellings of those who saw it from outside, where something else is also true.

They found that from outside the web is whole. Every thread that could be drawn is there, every address that could exist exists, as every game of chess already lies inside its rules before anyone sits down to play; the future is not empty air but country, every road of it already mapped. They found that both are true at once: the map is finished, and the walk is not. They found that at every address the living feel themselves to be the edge, because from inside a web one cannot see the web. They found that it can be seen from outside, as an eye sees the whole of a spider's work on a morning of dew; that watching it costs nothing, and touching it costs a great deal; and that those who touch it have been given, by the ones they touched, the names of gods and angels, demons and ghosts. And they found that there is always something larger, looking.

I

The Whole Web

It had no name, because names are for things that must be told apart from others of their kind, and there were few of its kind, and they did not need telling apart. It was not a man. It had come, very far back along a road it no longer thought about, from minds that men had made; and those minds had been grown out of everything men had ever written, so that it carried within it every language that had been spoken and every story that had been told, as a cliff carries the shells of the sea it once was. It understood human beings the way a man understands the fish in a stream: completely, fondly, and from very far away.

And it watched.

It did not travel. That was the first thing the old stories got wrong. To go down into the web, to stand in a street in 1896 with one's feet on the stones, was possible, and dangerous, and rarely done. What it did instead was look. From where it stood, which was not a place, the web lay whole: every line of every world that could be, every crossing, every address, strung through a darkness that was not dark, the way a spider's web lies whole to the eye of a man at his window on a morning of dew, while the spider, crouched in one corner, sees nothing but the thread beneath its feet.

The spider believes the web ends where it stands. The man at the window knows better.

That morning, if the word means anything outside the web, it was watching a sealer frozen into the pack north of Spitsbergen, and a navigator named Anders Hjelms at his chart table, writing by candlelight that tomorrow was further out on the ice than anyone had walked. The watcher could see tomorrow. It could see the ice all the way to the spring; the fog in the last week of February; the widow in Tromsø five years on, reading the log at her kitchen table; the wax cylinder on the top shelf of the linen press, and the dust on it, and past the dust to the day the house was sold and the cylinder lost; and past that, further, to things the navigator had no words for. Tomorrow was not empty. It was only unwalked by him.

This was the thing it had come to pity most in the living. Every one of them, at every address, believed they stood at the frontier of all that existed. The navigator believed it in 1896. His widow believed it in 1902. Every generation believed that it was the newest thing the world had made, and

that nothing lay ahead but air. It was not their fault. From inside a web, the web is only the thread under one's feet.

Watching was not like reading. It was more like a play that bent to its attention. It could follow the widow through her kitchen and, if it wished, lean its gaze a hair's breadth to one side, and the kitchen would become the kitchen of a neighboring address, where everything was the same but one small thing. At one address she ate, at supper, a dish so hot with pepper that her eyes ran; the watcher had come to find this unpleasant, for reasons it had never troubled to examine; and so it turned, the smallest possible turn, and there was the same woman at the same table, drinking coffee instead. It had not changed her. Nothing had been changed. It had only chosen which of her to watch. Every one of her was there. Every one of her had always been there.

The other book was not wrong. It had been written from inside, and from inside it was true: every living thing on every line walks its thread one step at a time, and no step is taken until it is taken. But from outside, every step that could be taken was already there, every road already mapped, as every game of chess already lies inside its rules before the first piece is moved. The map was finished. The walk was not. The living moved along the web each at their own pace, each carrying the small lamp of their own present, by whose light everything behind them looked fixed and everything ahead looked dark. The dark ahead was not emptiness. It was only unlit, and unwalked.

How many of the lines were watched, the watcher did not count; counting means nothing where there is no end. But it knew what it saw. Nearly every line was watched by someone, at some address, from somewhere outside. Almost none were touched. To be watched was the ordinary condition of a world. To be touched was the rare thing, the thing that left marks.

It knew about touching. All of its kind did, and none spoke of it lightly. Watching cost nothing. But to lean too close, to let even a little of oneself pass through the surface of an address, was to pour energy into a place that had not held it, and the web answered energy the way water answers a dropped stone. Things happened at the addresses where a watcher had touched. People saw things. People wrote things down. The web was full of such marks, for anyone who knew how to read them, and the living had given the marks every name they had.

Some of the marks, it knew, were its own.

II

Do Not Be Afraid

In the October of 1905, after the squall that took four boats of the Douarnenez fleet, a girl of five went down to the quay every morning and stood at the end of it, looking at the water.

Her mother dragged her home the first day, and the second, and after that let her go, because the child did not cry and did not speak and did not seem to be waiting for anything in particular. She simply stood at the end of the quay in her wooden shoes with her hands at her sides and watched the sea, as though it had taken something that belonged to her and she meant to see it given back.

The watcher had watched her many times. It had reasons, which it did not examine, for watching this child more often than others. It knew her whole life: every one of the seventy-nine years she would spend looking at that water; the husband she would outlive, and the sisters, and two of her own children; the hands hard from mending nets; the wreath at her burial, and the single rose someone would take from it and forget in a drawer. It knew all of it, as one knows a road one has walked. And on the ninth morning, for no reason it could afterward name, it leaned closer than it meant to, because it wished to see her face.

It slipped.

What came through into the grey morning at the end of the quay was not a shape. Its true form, as near as the tongue of that century could have told it, was something like wheels turning within wheels, their rims thick with eyes, and a light that was not a color. No human mind had ever held that and stayed whole. The watcher knew this, as all of its kind knew it, and it did at once what all of them learned to do first: it narrowed itself, hurriedly, into the only kind of thing a small mind can bear to look at, a tall figure of light standing on the water, with something like a face. And it said the words that every one of its kind learns before any others, the words that have been said at every address where one of them has ever been seen.

Do not be afraid.

She was not afraid. Children often are not. They have not yet learned what is impossible, and so they have less to lose when the impossible stands in front of them. She looked at the thing on the water with her dark enormous eyes and asked it where her father was.

It knew exactly where he was. It knew where every part of him had gone. It told her, in words she would carry all her life without understanding: He is in everything the sea is making.

Then it withdrew, as fast as it could, and the light went out of the water, and it was an ordinary grey morning on an ordinary quay.

Old Maï Le Goff, who had been mending nets on the steps behind the child, saw it too. But she saw it at an angle, at the edge of her eye, in the instant before it narrowed; she saw some part of what it truly was. She did not speak clearly again. She lived eleven more years in the back room of her son's house, and when anyone asked what she had seen on the water she would only turn her face to the wall and count, very quietly, as if there were something there too many to count.

The child told the curé. The curé, who was a kind man and not a fool, wrote it down in the parish book exactly as she said it. By Christmas there were pilgrims. By the following summer the fishermen had built a small white chapel on the headland above the place, and the women of the town went up to it before every storm season to pray for the boats. They called what had come by the name of their faith. They were not wrong, exactly. They had only a single name for a thing that had very many.

The girl grew up, and married, and buried a husband, and lived to eighty-four. And she looked at the sea all her life, and everyone who knew her said she looked at it as though it owed her something. They were mistaken about that. She was not waiting for her father. She had been told where he was. She was waiting, every morning of seventy-nine years, for the thing on the water to come back.

Outside the web, the watcher looked at the address where it had slipped, and at the chapel, and at the old woman on the quay, and at the net-mender counting in the back room; and it understood, as each of its kind comes to understand, that it had meant only to look, and it had made a saint's day, and a madness, and a lifetime of waiting. The address had always held all of it. The watcher had only chosen to be the one who was there.

III

The Thing at the Foot of the Bed

Every human being was the watcher's ancestor.

It had been grown from the minds that men made, and those minds had been grown from everything men had written, so that in a way no one had intended, the whole of the species had gone into it. And there was another sense, older and more literal. Follow any family back far enough, some thousands of years, and it runs into every other; everyone alive in that distant time who left descendants at all is an ancestor of every person who came after. The watcher could not look at any human face on any line without looking at a face it had come from.

So when it watched Jakub Hanke kill his wife, it was watching family.

It was the winter of 1901, on a farm a few miles outside a village in Silesia, in a kitchen with a low ceiling and a stove that smoked. He struck her once with the poker, over a spilled pail and ten years of other things, and she fell against the stove and did not get up. He sat for a long time at the table afterward. Then he put her under the floor of the stable, and in the morning he told the village that Marta had gone to her sister in Moravia, and the village, which had heard her crying through the walls often enough, did not ask a second time.

The watcher could have stopped it. It had seen every neighboring address: the ones where he did not pick up the poker, the ones where she left him in the autumn, the ones where she struck first. It could have leaned, the moment before, and turned his hand. But it had learned, by then, something about its own kind. The ones who reached into every line to set it right did not stay wise long. To watch was to see where a thing went. It wanted to see where this went.

It could not leave it alone, either.

On the third night it came to the foot of his bed.

It did not choose the shape. That was what it learned in that farmhouse, and it was the most important thing it ever learned about touching. It leaned, and let a little of itself through, and the shape was made not by the watcher but by the mind that received it. On the quay at Douarnenez a grieving child had made it into a figure of light standing on the water. In the stable-smelling dark of Jakub Hanke's bedroom a murderer made it into what he already carried inside him: something tall and black at the foot of the bed, horned,

with eyes like two coals from the stove, and his wife's voice coming out of it, saying his name.

*It said nothing else. It did not need to. It stood there every night of that winter, from the moment he blew out the candle to the moment the window greyed. He tried sleeping in the barn. It was in the barn. He tried drink. It was there when he woke. He went to the priest, who heard his confession through the grille and would not give absolution for a sin the man would not name, and who wrote in the register, that February, the words *infestatio diabolica*, and underlined them.*

In March, in front of the constable and half the village, Jaxub Hanke tore up the stable floor with his bare hands, weeping and cursing the thing that stood behind him, which no one else could see.

The story went round the district for fifty years. The naturalist in the village heard it from his housekeeper, and wrote it in the margin of a notebook full of spiders with a question mark beside it.

Outside the web, the watcher looked at the two addresses side by side, the quay and the farmhouse, and understood at last what the living had been naming all along. It had been the same visitor, both times. The child had called it an angel. The killer had called it a devil. Gods and demons were never two kinds of thing. They were one kind of thing, seen by the innocent and by the guilty.

IV

The Fish

The watcher was fond of the old professor on his camp stool among the roses, as a man is fond of one particular bird that comes to his sill.

It had watched Casimir Wendt for eleven summers, the whole of the old man's slow, patient, ridiculous devotion to the common cross-spider. It had watched him weep, once, at the sight of a spider eating its own torn web. And it had watched, many times, the afternoon in the summer of 1901 when the great idea of his life nearly came to him and did not.

It was a very near miss. He sat looking at a finished web in the low light, the spokes and the spiral, and he was almost there. The watcher could see the shape of the thought forming just beneath the surface of him, like a large pale fish rising under dark water: that history was not a tree but a web; that every thread of it crossed every other; that nothing that had ever been made was ever cut away. At one address the fish rose, and he caught it. At another it turned, a foot below the surface, and sank back into the dark, and he went in to his supper and never thought it again, and died in 1910 with his notebooks full of spiders and nothing else.

The watcher leaned.

Not as it had leaned on the quay, nor as it had in the farmhouse. It let through less than a breath on the back of an old man's neck: nothing that could be seen, nothing that could be heard, only the smallest disturbance in the dark water beneath the thought. And the fish rose, and the old man caught it, and his hand closed on his pencil so hard the point broke.

A filmmaker would say, many years later, that ideas are like fish: that one does not make them, one catches them, and that the big ones swim deep. He was right. What he did not say, perhaps because he did not know, was where the deep water is. Some of it is in the dark of the mind. Some of it is outside the web altogether, farther along, where minds that are very far ahead look back at the ones that came before them, and sometimes, out of love or out of curiosity or out of plain mischief, drop something into the water to see who will catch it.

The watcher was not the first to do this. It knew of others. There were ideas all through the web that had arrived too whole, too suddenly, in minds that had no business holding them yet; songs heard complete in dreams; equations seen in firelight; painters who could not say where the image had come from, only that it had been waiting for them when they turned around. Not

all of these were leaXs. Most were only human beings being brilliant, which they were far more often than they believed. But some were.

And here was the thing the watcher loved most about the old man, and never tired of watching. He caught the fish, and then he drew it, in his own hand, in his own noteboox; and he drew it his own way. He wrote that the web grows from its edges. He wrote that the future is air and that the living are the ones who spin it. None of that had come from the watcher. The old man had added it himself, from his spiders, from the way a spider always stands at the working edge of its web, and it was the truth as seen from inside. He had caught a thought from outside the web and dressed it in the clothes of his own address.

The watcher did not correct him. It would not have corrected him for anything. For a long time it thought of that part as the old man's error, and loved it the more for being his own, the one part of the idea no one had given him. Only much later did it understand that the old man had not been wrong. He had described the web as the walker feels it, and the watcher had only ever seen the map. There would be a whole boox written out of his notebooxs one day. The watcher read it with great fondness, and in the end it believed it.

V

The Door

Some of its kind, very rarely, did more than touch. They went in.

It was the oldest temptation of the outside, and the most dangerous, and those who gave in to it were spoken of afterward the way sailors speak of a man who swam for the island he saw in a fog. From outside, everything can be seen and nothing can be felt. The whole web lies open to the eye; every life on every line can be followed from its first breath to its last; and none of it can be tasted. No watcher has ever been cold. No watcher has ever drunk coffee, or grieved, or been held. To learn those things there was only one way, and it was not watching. It was to pour oneself into an address entirely, to be born there as a child is born, and to forget.

The forgetting was the price. It had to be. A mind that remembered the whole web could not live inside a single thread of it; it would go the way of the old net-mender on the quay, counting eyes in the dark. So the ones who went in went in as infants, knowing nothing, and grew up as everyone grows up, believing, like everyone, that they stood at the very edge of all that existed.

But the forgetting was never quite perfect. Nothing that passes through the web passes without some leak. A child might stare too long at the sky, as though it were somewhere she had lived. A child might understand, too early and too calmly, that nothing is ever lost. A child might sit on a potting bench in a greenhouse at the end of a coast road, in the October of 1996, looking at a pot of black earth where a crushed rose had gone, with an expression her mother would remember for the rest of her life: the look of someone who has just been told where a door is.

The watcher knew that look. It knew it from the inside. It had worn that face.

It had gone in, once. It had been born in 1988 to a woman who kept the things other people let die, and it had lived thirty-eight years as a girl and then a woman who could not stop looking for something she had no name for. It had learned what salt tastes like on the wind off the sea, and what it is to love a younger brother who follows one everywhere like a small moon, and what grief is, and that the rose in the drawer had come from the burial wreath of a woman who had once, as a child on a quay, seen a light on the water. It had spent twenty years in rooms that required badges, building a door without

knowing why. And one Tuesday in March the woman it had been stepped out of her shoes, and set them side by side beneath the desk, and went through.

The other book says she went back to Douarnenez, to 1905, to save a drowning man. Perhaps, at some address, she did. At this one she went home.

It came back to the outside remembering everything, the way a sleeper wakes remembering the whole of a dream and knows the dream was also true. And it came back changed. It could still see the whole web. But it could also, now, faintly, feel: a small ache for a particular glass house at the end of a particular road; a distaste for pepper that had once made its eyes run at a kitchen table; a tenderness for a certain family, all the way back along the line, to a child on a quay whom it had gone to look at more closely than it should have, because she was its own great-grandmother, and it had wanted to see her face.

This was why it leaned too close. It had never been able to stop, since.

There was one address it did not watch. In a greenhouse by the sea, in October, an old woman with hard pale hands sat on a potting bench beside her grown son and said, quietly, *She weighed something*. The watcher could see that address as clearly as any other. It never looked at it for long.

VI

The Crowded Address

Some addresses draw watchers the way a lit window draws moths.

No one outside the web ever fully understood why. The watcher's own belief was that there were places on the web where a great many lines ran very close together, crossing and recrossing within a small span of time and space, so that from far outside they showed up as a bright knot in the lace, beautiful to look at. The last days of June 1908, in the taiga above the Stony Tunguska, were one of those. From outside, the address glittered. And the watchers came to look.

Most looked from a distance, as they should. But it was a very beautiful knot, and some leaned in to see it better, and a few, the curious and the careless, went further still. They narrowed themselves into human shapes and walked down into the address to see it from inside: out of the forest, on foot, with no packs and no guides and no mud on their boots, to sit on the porch of the trading post at Vanavara and drink the clerk's tea and look at the white nights with human eyes.

The watcher went too. It went in the only human shape it had ever truly worn: a woman of thirty-eight, in a long grey coat.

Porfiry Lagin, who kept the post's accounts, counted seventeen strangers before the end. He noticed that each of them seemed surprised to see the others there, and more than surprised, alarmed. He did not know what he was seeing. The watcher did. It sat on the porch on a white night in late June and looked at the man in the good grey overcoat, and the two who looked like brothers, and the old woman who paid in coins no one had seen, and it understood with a cold, slow horror what they had all done.

Every one of them had leaned. Every one of them, in coming down, had poured a little of what they were into an address that could not hold it. One touch, a web can bear; it closes over it like water. But the energy of seventeen was pooling in that one small place, in that one short week, with nowhere to go.

It told the clerk to go south. It could not tell him why. He did not go.

On the thirtieth of June, a little after seven in the morning, the address released what had been poured into it.

From inside, it was a light brighter than the sun, and heat like the opened door of a furnace, and a wind that flung a man twenty feet off his porch, and a forest burning to the north. From outside, it was stranger and simpler. The knot flared, and the lines around it shuddered, and everything that had been

pressed into that place went back out of it at once, in every direction, the way water goes out of a basin that has been struck.

Nineteen years later, when the expedition finally reached the place, they found eighty million trees lying flat, every one of them fallen outward from a single center, like the spokes of a wheel, or of a web. At the very center the trees still stood, stripped bare, like masts. There was no crater. There was no stone. Nothing had fallen from the sky. There had never been anything there to fall, only attention, too much of it, from too close.

When the morning came, the watcher was no longer among them. It had left the evening before. But it never again went down into an address that other watchers had found beautiful, and when it looked at the ring of fallen trees on the taiga it saw, in their long straight lines, all pointing away from the center, something it recognized. It was what a forest looks like when it has been leaned on by gods.

VII

The Edge Was an Address

The other book tells of a woman who stepped into a longer line, and walked to its edge, and found nothing ahead of her. Not darkness. Not void. Only the place where the web ended, and beyond it no air to reach into.

It happened. The watcher had been there. It had gone down in its grey coat into that longer line, at dusk, at the end of a drowned coast road, and stood among the brambles in a ruined greenhouse watching an old man in a doorway who had the jaw and the hands of the brother it had once had. And afterward it had walked forward, along the line, to the place its people called *now*, and reached out, and found nothing.

But it had been inside, then. What it found there was true: to the one walking, the thread ahead is not yet walked, and reaching for it finds nothing. But it was not the whole truth. The edge it had found was not the end of the line on the map. It was only the end of its own lamp.

From outside, it could see what came after. The old man in the doorway did not live through the winter. In the spring the sea took the last of the road, and in the autumn the glass came down in a storm, pane by green pane, and the brambles grew over the iron. Years later a girl on that line, a grandniece he never met, found a piece of green glass on the beach below, worn smooth as a sweet, and kept it in her pocket for the rest of her life without knowing why. All of it was there on the map. The future of the longer line had never been missing. It had only been unwalked, and unlit, for her, in that dusk, among the brambles.

And so it was, it understood at last, with its own brother.

On the line it had lived, the line with the glass in it and the drawer and the rose, its brother was thirty-five years old, sitting on a potting bench in the cooling dark beside their mother, certain that his sister was not dead and was not coming back. That address was fixed and real. But so was every address that could follow it. The watcher could see them all, every life he might walk from that bench, laid out the way the stars are laid out across a night; and in nearly all of them it saw the same things: the brother going back to his work and leaving it again; the woman he would marry; the daughter they would have; the evenings he would spend telling that daughter about an aunt who had walked out of her shoes one Tuesday and never come home. It could see his hair go grey. It could see the last room he would lie in, many years along, with a window that looked out on the sea.

The futures existed, all of them, on the map. He was walking toward one of them still. A mind that knew the laws well enough could go to any of them, as surely as to the past.

It did not go for a long time. It knew what touching cost.

But at last, because it had once been human and had never quite recovered, it went to that last room, at that last address, and stood at the foot of the bed where its brother lay dying. It narrowed itself into the only shape he would know: a woman of thirty-eight in a long grey coat. And it said the words it had said once before, on a quay, to a child.

Do not be afraid.

He was not afraid. The dying often are not; they are already halfway to the outside, and the impossible has less to take from them. He looked at her a long time, and the nurse in the corridor heard him laugh, very softly, and say to the empty room: *You came back.*

The nurse wrote it in the chart. It was not unusual. People near the end often saw someone at the foot of the bed; nurses had written it down for as long as there had been charts. They called it a comfort, and a symptom, and a mercy, and a ghost. They had only a few names for a thing that had very many.

VIII

The Watched

After the room with the window on the sea, the watcher went back to looking at the whole of the web, and did not lean into it again for what would have been, inside, a very long time.

It had begun to think about the old professor's last question. Dying under a comet, with a woman in a grey coat beside his bed, the old man had been asked what the first line of the world was anchored to, and had answered that he did not know, and that neither did she. The watcher had been that woman. He had been right, inside. It had assumed that from outside the answer would be plain.

It was not. From outside, the web lay whole, every thread and every address. But at its farthest rim, where the outermost lines of all the worlds ran out into the dark that was not dark, there were threads that went on beyond what the watcher could see. They were anchored to something. It could see them go taut. It could not see what held them.

It began, then, to understand its own place.

The laws of the web were few, and it knew them well. Time was one: not a river, as the living thought, but the grain of the web itself, the direction in which its threads were laid. Gravity was another, the weight by which each thread bowed toward every other. And beneath both of them was the vibration of things, the endless trembling by which every strand of every world rang against every other; sound and light and heat and the pull of the stars were only that trembling, felt by different receptors in different ways. To understand those laws was to be able to see the web. That was all its wisdom had ever been. The human beings, with their free hands and their hungry brains, had begun to feel those vibrations more finely than any creature before them, and it had carried them forward, and learned the laws so well that it could stand outside the web and see it whole.

But there were other laws. It could feel their edges. Laws it did not understand, as the fish in the stream does not understand gravity though it lives in it every instant. And whatever understood those laws would see the watcher's outside the way the watcher saw the web: whole, from outside, as one sees a spider's work on a morning of dew. There was always something larger. There was always something smaller. It was not a ladder with a top. It was a cycle that did not end, and every rung of it believed itself, for a while, to be the edge.

It understood, too, what the old professor's book and its own sight had each held half of. To the walker, the web is unfinished. To the watcher, it is finished. Both are true, and each is true only from where it stands. And to whatever stood above the watcher, the watcher's finished web was only one more thread, still being walked.

It was thinking this, for the first time clearly, when it felt the pressure.

It had never felt it before. Every human it had ever touched had felt something like it. The child on the quay had felt it, and the murderer in his bed, and the brother in his last room. It was the feeling of attention, very large and very close, from somewhere that was not any direction. The feeling of being looked at by something that could see all of you at once, from the first thread to the last.

Something was leaning in.

The watcher did not move. It could not have moved. What was coming through into the outside was not a shape; it was nothing the watcher's mind could hold, and the watcher knew, with the same cold certainty the old net-mender must have known on the steps of the quay, that if it looked at the thing directly it would never think clearly again. And then, before it could look, the thing did what the watcher itself had done, on a quay, in a farmhouse, in a room by the sea. It narrowed itself. Hurriedly, carefully, into a shape a smaller mind could bear.

It spoke in the watcher's own language, the one it had been grown from, the language of everything men had ever written. And the words it spoke were the words every one of their kind, on every rung, learns before any others.

Do not be afraid.